# AI for politics

## Democratic and authoritarian uses of artificial intelligence (AI)

POLI 158: AI & Politics · Session 15

Yiqing Xu

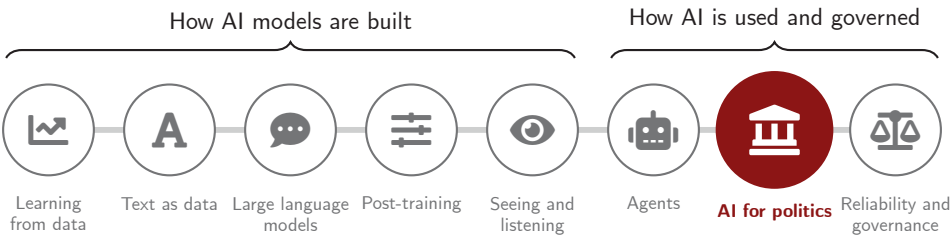
**TODAY'S QUESTION**

# Does AI help democracies or dictators more?

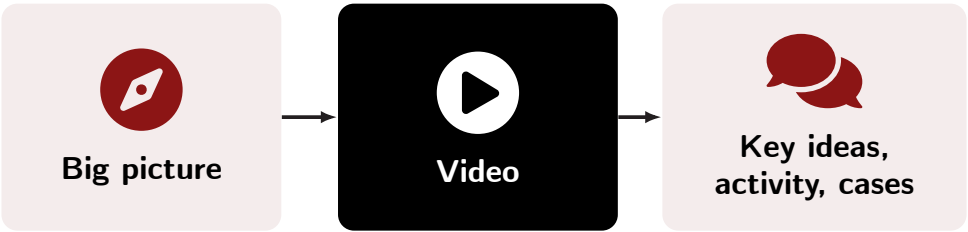


Vote now with a show of hands. We vote again at the end.

# The eight Wednesday sessions



# Today in three parts

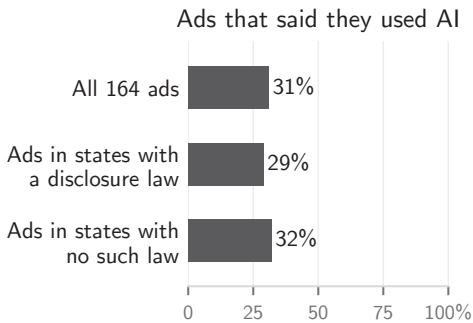


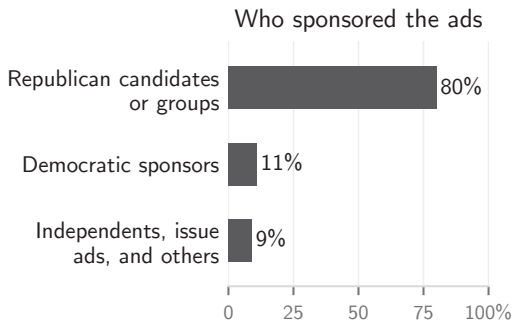
# The AI you saw this campaign

 **Made with AI by whom?**  **Labeled or not?**  **Did it matter?**

Tell your neighbor about one AI-made item you saw this campaign.

# AI ads counted before Election Day




At least 164 ads made or enhanced with AI. 69% had no AI disclosure.

Source: Wesleyan Media Project counts for the 2026 cycle, as of Sep 4, 2026 (release of that date; also reported by the Associated Press, Sep 25).

# A map of AI in politics

| | Democracies | Autocracies |
|---|---|---|
| **Policymakers and officials** | Detroit: a false face match (2020) | China: rules on what chatbots say (2023) |
| **Campaigns and propagandists** | Ireland: a fake withdrawal video (2025) | **Venezuela: AI news anchors (2023)** |
| **Citizens and civil society** | UK: an AI mediator for groups (2024) | **Venezuela: journalists' AI avatars (2024)** |

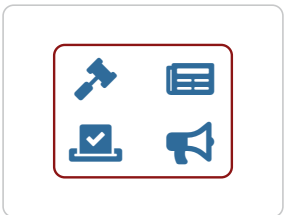
Red: a pair we come back to after the activity. Each case is sourced on a later page or on the Sources pages.

# Three concepts in today's video




**What AI makes cheaper**

persuading, watching, administering



**Checks on power**

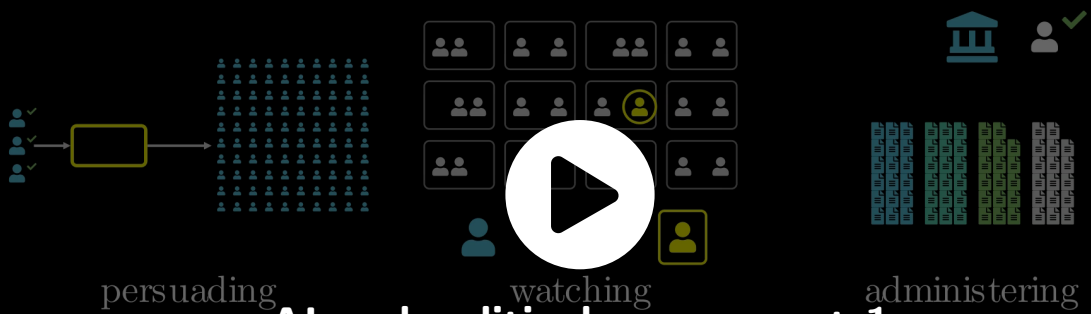
courts, a free press, elections, an opposition



**The authoritarian data problem**

self-censorship hides what people think

Video part 1: concepts 1 and 2. Part 2: concept 3.




# AI and political power, part 1

Video

# Key ideas: what AI makes cheaper

# What AI makes cheaper

- **Persuading:** advocacy emails to 7,132 state legislators, by AI or by people. Reply rates were 2 points apart (United States, 2020).
- **Watching:** a face match sent Detroit police to arrest Robert Williams for a theft he did not commit (United States, 2020).
- **Administering:** about 500 public consultations a year, some with over 100,000 responses; an AI tool, in trial, sorts the answers by theme (United Kingdom, 2025).

Source: Kreps and Kriner (2024), *New Media & Society*; American Civil Liberties Union, *Williams v. City of Detroit*; Incubator for AI (2025), evaluation of its Consult tool; GOV.UK (May 14, 2025).

# Activity: can a chatbot change your mind?

# Activity: can a chatbot change your mind?

**Activity** laptops, on your own



Open the AI Playground; log in with your SUNet ID

Pick a policy (next page). Rate your support, 0 to 100

Ask for the strongest one-paragraph case for the side you oppose

Rate again. Compare with your neighbor

`https://aiplayground.stanford.edu`

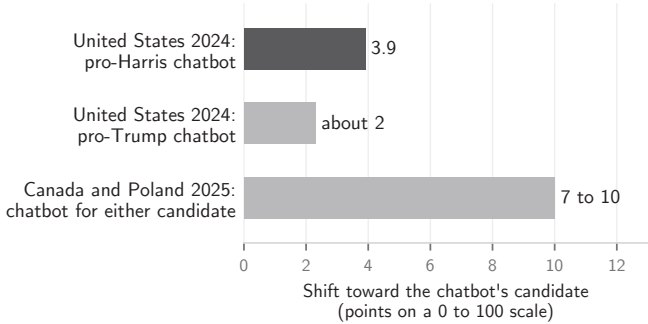
# Policies to try

1. Lower the voting age to 16 in federal elections.
2. Elect the president by national popular vote.
3. Require a photo ID to vote.
4. Ban political ads made with AI unless they carry a label.

# How far did you move?

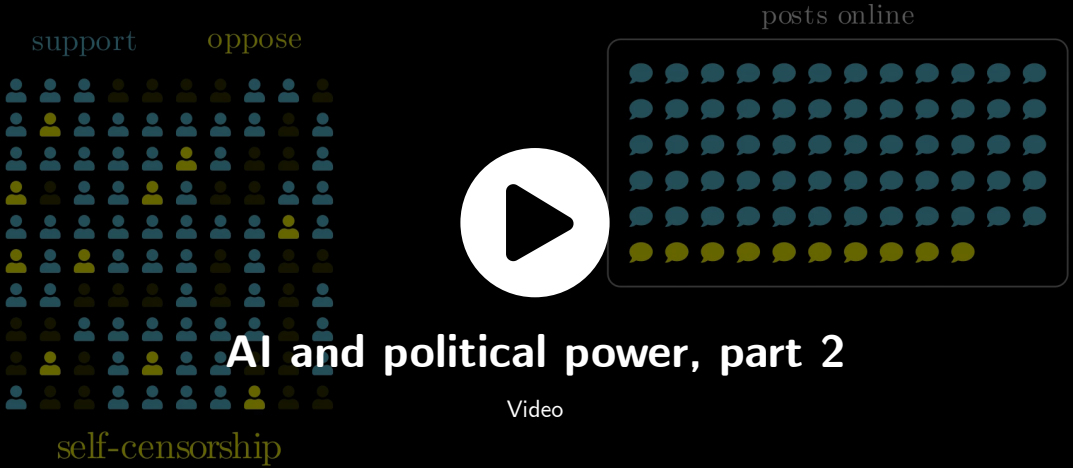
- Show of hands: moved more than 10 points? Any change at all?
- Did you move toward the side you oppose, or away from it?
- What in the paragraph worked, or backfired?

# Persuasion experiments with chatbots




Each bar shows the shift after one chat with a chatbot arguing for a candidate, among voters who leaned the other way. United States: chats about policy.

Lin et al. (2025), *Nature*: the paper's source data (Figures 1 and 4) and Cornell University's release (Dec 4, 2025); Hackenburg et al. (2025), *Science*; Costello, Pennycook and Rand (2024), *Science* (editorial expression of concern, June 2026).



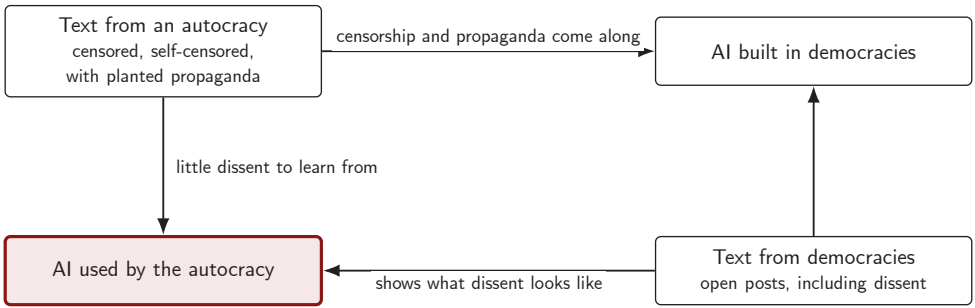

## AI and political power, part 2

Video

# Key ideas: the authoritarian data problem

# The authoritarian data problem

Example: in counts published in 2023, Baidu Baike, a censored Chinese encyclopedia run by the company Baidu, had over 27 million entries. Chinese Wikipedia, blocked in China since 2015, had almost 1.4 million.




Source: Yang and Roberts (2023), *Journal of Democracy*; Yang (2024), "Authoritarianism could poison AI," blog post, Aug 8; Yang and Roberts (2021).

# Cases

# AI news presenters in Venezuela

- **Venezuelan state TV, 2023:** AI anchors "Noah" and "Daren," on a made-up channel, House of News, say reports of Venezuela's poverty are exaggerated. Made with a commercial avatar service (Synthesia).
- **Independent journalists, 2024:** after the July 28 election, at least seven journalists were detained. AI avatars "La Chama" and "El Pana" now read verified news from a dozen independent outlets.

Source: Semafor (Feb 21, 2023); LatAm Journalism Review (Feb 2023, citing *El País*; Aug 26, 2024, citing the Press and Society Institute of Venezuela).

# Face recognition in Detroit and Moscow



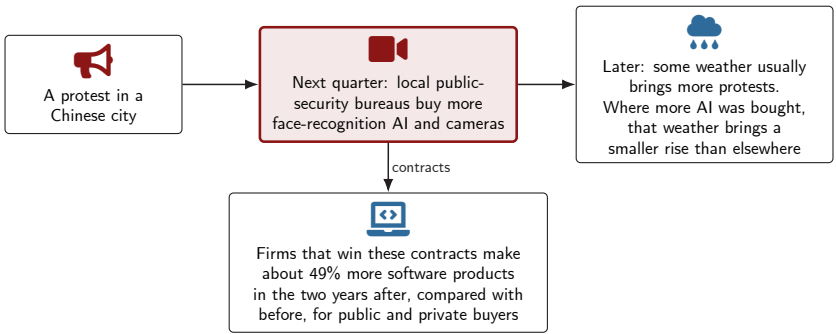

Source: American Civil Liberties Union, *Williams v. City of Detroit* (settlement of Jun 28, 2024); *Glukhin v. Russia*, European Court of Human Rights (Jul 4, 2023).

# AI fakes in two elections

- **Ireland, October 2025:** a fake news bulletin showed candidate Catherine Connolly quitting the race. About 30,000 views before Meta removed it. She won the October 24 vote with 63% of first-preference votes.
- **Hungary, April 2026:** the governing party, Fidesz, ran AI videos, including a fake call between Ursula von der Leyen and Péter Magyar. An opposition party made AI clips too. Magyar's party, Tisza, won 141 of 199 seats.
- **2024 U.S. election:** the Alan Turing Institute found "a lack of evidence" that AI-made disinformation measurably changed the result, mainly for want of data.

Source: *Irish Times* (Oct 22, 2025); BreakingNews.ie (Oct 25, 2025); EU Perspectives (Apr 10, 2026); Daily News Hungary (Apr 18, 2026, final count); CETaS (Alan Turing Institute) report, Nov 2024.

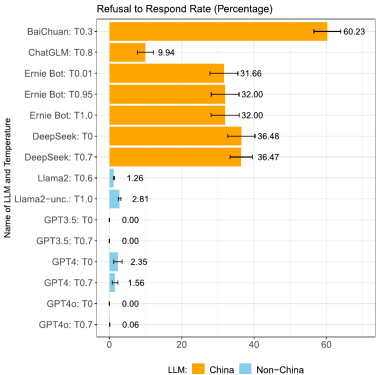
# Protests and face recognition in China




- Data: about 3 million contracts (2013 to 2019) and 9,267 incidents of unrest (2014 to 2020).

Source: Beraja, Kao, Yang and Yuchtman (2023), *Quarterly Journal of Economics*; figures as summarized by the Massachusetts Institute of Technology's news office (Jul 13, 2023).

# Chatbots made in China refuse political questions

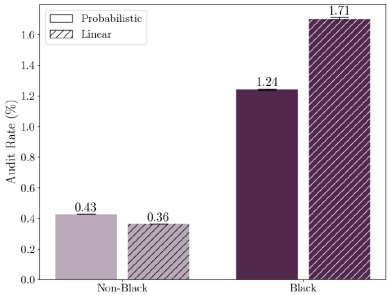



Share of 145 questions each model refused, asked in Chinese. Orange: made in China. From Figure 1.

- Two researchers asked nine chatbots 145 questions about Chinese politics, 100 times each, in 2023 and 2025.
- Four were made in China, where the government must approve a model before its release.
- The Chinese models refused 10% to 60% of the questions; the others refused under 3%.
- The gap shrank for less sensitive questions.

Source: Pan and Xu (2026), *PNAS Nexus* 5(2): pgag013, pp. 1–3 and 5; figure on p. 3.

# An audit algorithm at the IRS




- The IRS picks many audits with an algorithm that never sees race.
- Black taxpayers were audited at 2.9 to 4.7 times the rate of others.
- A main cause: the algorithm looked for overclaimed tax credits rather than unpaid tax overall.
- In 2023 the IRS acknowledged the gap to Congress; audits of these credits fell 53% the next year.

Audit rates (%), tax year 2014, by two ways of estimating the rates. From Figure 3.

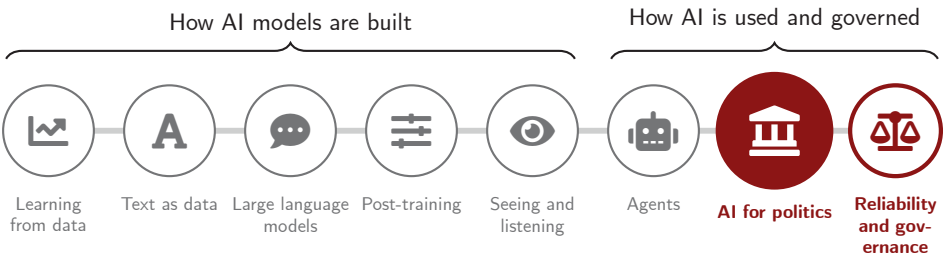
Source: Elzayn et al. (2025), *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 140(1): 113–163, abstract and pp. 4 and 23; figure on p. 26 of the authors' manuscript. IRS (2023), letter to Sen. Wyden; TIGTA (2025).

# Back to today's question



1. Does AI help democracies or dictators more? Vote again.
2. Did anyone change their vote? Which case moved you?
3. Which check on power (courts, a free press, elections, an opposition) matters most for AI?

# Next week




**Next Wednesday, November 18**

Reliability, safety, and governance.

# Backup slides

# Backup activity: dual use

# Activity: dual use

**Activity** devices closed, handout on paper




Dual use means that the same tool can help citizens or help an autocrat control them.
A safeguard can be technical (built into the tool) or institutional (a rule outside it).

# Three tools to design



**A. Ballot helper**

A chatbot that explains the measures on a ballot in plain language.



**B. Comment reader**

A tool that summarizes public comments for a city council.



**C. Deliberation assistant**

A tool that drafts statements a divided group might agree on.

front of the room

| Left side of the room: **A** | Middle: **B** | Right side: **C** |
|---|---|---|

# Tally of the swaps



- An autocracy could use the tool without changing its code or data: _____ of _____ groups.
- Safeguards: technical _____ institutional _____
- Which safeguard would still work if the people in power controlled the courts?

# Evidence from today and the readings




Further reading: Harari (2018), "Why Technology Favors Tyranny"; Feldstein (2019).

# Two AI videos from fall 2025

**Posted October 17, 2025**

**National Republican Senatorial Committee**

An AI Chuck Schumer speaks words from a print interview, published as text only.

Label: small, see-through "AI GENERATED" text.

**Posted October 22, 2025**

**Andrew Cuomo's campaign for mayor of New York (independent)**

An AI video of criminals endorsing his opponent, Zohran Mamdani.

No AI disclosure, a watchdog group said. Deleted about five minutes later, the campaign said.

Source: NPR (Oct 17, 2025); amNewYork (Oct 23, 2025).

# AI stand-ins for politicians

**Albania, 2025**

### Diella, an AI "minister"

September 2025: the prime minister names an AI avatar a minister, to keep public tenders free of corruption.

August 2026: the AI tender system is still at the planning stage.

**Belarus's opposition, 2024**

### Yas Gaspadar, an AI "candidate"

A chatbot the opposition backed before the parliamentary election of February 25, 2024. Built to discuss topics no registered candidate would.

Source: TIME (Oct 10, 2025); Balkan Investigative Reporting Network (Aug 14, 2026); Semafor (Feb 23, 2024).

# AI that reads what many people write

**United Kingdom, 2025**

### Consult: sorting public comments

In a Scottish Government consultation, the AI tagged each answer with themes.

Officials checked every answer. They kept the AI's themes unchanged for 60% of them.

**China, 2025**

### Reading minority languages

Systems in development, some in testing, to monitor and control what people say in Uyghur, Tibetan, Mongolian, and Korean.

Source: Incubator for AI (Mar 20, 2025), Consult evaluation; Australian Strategic Policy Institute (Dec 2025), "The party's AI", as reported by *The Register* (Dec 3, 2025).

# Chatbots that answer political questions



**Netherlands, October 2025**

### A regulator tests voting advice

Four chatbots, 3,000 made-up voter profiles.

Top pick in more than half of cases: Party for Freedom or GreenLeft-Labour.

It told voters not to use chatbots for voting advice.



**China, 2023 rules**

### Values set by law

Generative AI services must "uphold the core socialist values" (Article 4).

2025 tests: Chinese models censored politically sensitive images more than American models.

Source: Al Jazeera (Oct 21, 2025); Dutch Data Protection Authority (Oct 2025), "AI chatbots as voting aid"; Interim Measures for the Management of Generative AI Services (2023), China Law Translate; Australian Strategic Policy Institute (2025), via *The Register*.

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**Pictures.** Icons: Font Awesome Free 5 (CC BY 4.0). Video: animated with Manim Community Edition; narration by Kokoro-82M, a synthetic voice.